lighted candles. Angry over the slight, one of the Bahri Regiment's commanders, a Turk named Baibars, plotted Turan-shah's assassination.[13]

The murder left Egypt without a sultan. But Turan-shah had not been in Egypt long enough to be popular—in fact, his butchered body, swelling with decay, lay on the ground outside his camp for three days before anyone bothered to bury it—and no reprisals followed. Baibars and his confederates, setting themselves up as a military government in Cairo, decided to honor Ayyub's widow as the titular ruler of Cairo, while they ran the government to suit themselves.

After threatening to void the deal, they also—eventually—agreed to honor Turan-shah's arrangements. On May 5, Louis handed over his half ransom and was set free, along with his two surviving brothers and most of his barons. He set sail immediately for Acre, arriving on May 14. "All Acre came in procession down to the sea to receive him at his coming, with passing great joy," Joinville writes.[14]

The king had survived, but there was little else to rejoice in. Hundreds of Crusader soldiers remained prisoners in Egypt. Louis had spent every penny and owed still more for the balance of his ransom. And the Crusade itself had failed: Jerusalem was still in Muslim hands.